

Session 9: Rebekah's Plan to Deceive Isaac

Key Takeaways

- The biblical narrative consistently critiques polygamy by always putting front and center the abuse, neglect, and objectification these women have to endure at the hands of men who accumulate wives.
- Rivqah hatches a plot that unfolds to the melody of the Genesis 3 failure story.

Yaaqov's Deceives His Brother and Father

This large section has three parts of unequal length, but there is a clear organization of the parts based on repeated words and the plot. (The chart below is adapted from Andrew Teeter, "Genesis Class Notes" and from the principles in his essay, "[Biblical Symmetry and Its Modern Detractors](#)," a paper delivered at the 2019 International Organization for the Study of the Old Testament.)

Genesis 26:34-35

- Esau takes **Hittite wives**

Genesis 27:1-40

- A - 27:1-5 **Yitskhaq & Esau** : The **father's plan** to **bless** his favored son **before his death**
A' - 27:6-17 **Rivqah & Yaaqov** : The **mother's counter-plan** to **bless** her favored son
B - 27:18-29 **Yaaqov & Yitskhaq** : Younger son enacts the **counter-plan**, **poem of blessing**
B' - 27:30-40 **Yitskhaq & Esau** : Older son finds out and is angry, **poem of non-blessing**

Genesis 27:41-28:9

- A - 27:41 **Son Esau's speech-plan** about murdering Yaaqov **after his father's death**
A' - 27:42-45 **Rivqah's counter-plan speech** to Yaaqov
B - 27:46 **Rivqah's speech to Yitskhaq** : **counter-plan** to save Yaaqov, "I hate **Hittite wives**"
B' - 28:1-5 **Yitskhaq's speech to Yaaqov** fulfills Rivqah's **counter-plan**, "No **Hittite wives**"
B'' - 28:6-7 **Son Esau** sees Yaaqov's **blessing**
B'' - 28:8-9 **Son Esau** sees **Hittite wives** evil in father's eyes, and takes **Ishmaelite wife**

Genesis 26:34-28:9. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Part one (Gen. 26:34-35) is a short narrative about Esau marrying two Hittite wives (like Lemek in Gen. 4:19-24) who are a source of contention with his parents. This opening panel matches the closing panels in part three (

Gen. 27:46-28:5 and 28:6-9) where Esau's wives become a partial motivation for sending Yaaqov to Mesopotamia and Esau takes another wife from a tribe related to his uncle Abraham.

The inner parts are bound together by two symmetrical cycles of plans and deceptive counterplans.

1. Deception Cycle 1 (27:1-40): Parents' Plans and the Blessing

- Yitskhaq selfishly plans to pass the divine blessing on to Esau in exchange for his favorite venison, even though the boys' birth oracle clearly stated that the older would be subservient to the younger (Gen. 25:23).
- Rivqah concocts a counterplan to obtain the blessing for her favorite son.
- In the following narrative about Yaaqov and Yitskhaq, the counterplan leads to an ill-gotten blessing. After that, in a story about Yitskhaq and Esau, the counterplan becomes known and leads to a non-blessing.

2. Deception Cycle 2 (27:41-28:5): Esau's Plan and the Family

- Esau plans to murder his deceptive brother for stealing his firstborn right and his blessing.
- Rivqah concocts a counterplan to save her son's life, which requires sending him into exile to her brother's family in Mesopotamia.
- In the following narrative about Yaaqov and Yitskhaq, Rivqah's plan is repeated and carried out. After that, Esau sees all this and realizes his wives are offensive to his parents, so he marries yet again.

Not only does Genesis 26:34-28:9 display a tight coherence through this symmetrical design, each of the key elements in this section picks up and develops specific themes from its matching part back in Genesis 25:19-34.

Genesis 25:19-34

- Rival sons born: Esau and Yaaqov
- Parents each have a favorite son
- Yaaqov usurps Esau's **firstborn right (Heb. *bekorah*)** with a meal

Genesis 26:1-33

- Yitskhaq the deceiver is blessed among the Philistines

Genesis 26:34-28:9

- Rival sons are older: Esau and Yaaqov
- Parents each favor one son
- Rivqah and Yaaqov usurp Yitskhaq and Esau's plans of **blessing (Heb. *berakah*)** with a meal

Genesis 25:19-28:9. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Key Words from Genesis 25:19-34

Gen. 25:20

“ And Yitskhaq was a son of forty years when he **took** Rivqah, daughter of Bethuel the Aramean from Paddan-aram, for himself as a wife.”

Gen. 25:28 Parents each love one favored son
“Yitskhaq **loved** Esau, because hunted-game was in his mouth, but Rivqah **loved** Yaaqov.”

Gen. 25:23 Birth oracle poem
“The **greater** will **serve** the **little one**”

Gen. 25:31-34 Yaaqov swindles Esau out of his **firstborn-right** (בכרה) for a meal
“and he ate and he drank”

Gen. 25:25 Esau comes out hairy (שער)

Gen. 25:26 Yaaqov is named for his behavior
“And his hand was grabbing **the heel ('aqev)** of Esau, and his named was called **Yaaqov**.”

Gen. 25:22 Rivqah's laments her difficult pregnancy
“If this is how it is, **why me** (למה זה אנכי)?!”

Key Words from Genesis 26:34-28:9

Gen. 26:34-35

“ **And Esau was a son of forty years and he took** Yehudith daughter of Beeriy the Hittite and Basemath daughter of Elon the Hittite, and they were a bitterness of spirit for Yitskhaq and Rivqah.”

Gen. 27:2-4 Yitskhaq wants to bless his favored son
“Hunt some hunted-game for me, and make me tasty-things just like I **love** ... so that I can bless you.”

Gen. 27:29 Blessing poem for Yaaqov
“May peoples **serve** you, and may people groups bow down to you. Be mightier than **your brother**, and may **your mother's sons** bow down to you.”

Gen. 27:18-30 Yaaqov tricks Yitskhaq and gets Esau's **blessing** (ברכה) for a meal
“and he ate ... and he drank,”

Gen. 27:15-16 Yaaqov dresses with animal hair (שער) to imitate his brother.

Gen. 27:36
“Isn't his name called **Yaaqov**, for he has **heel-grabbed** (Yaaqeveni) me these two times?”

Gen. 27:46 Rivqah laments Yaaqov's wife prospects
“If Yaaqov takes a Hittite wife ... **why should I live** (למה לי חיים)?!”

Keywords from Genesis 25:19-28:9. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Genesis 26:34-35 Instructor's Translation

³⁴ And Esau was a son of forty years, when he took a wife,

Judith, daughter of Beerli the Hittite,
and Basemath, daughter of Elon the Hittite,
³⁵ and they were a bitterness of spirit for Isaac and Rebekah.

The Many Wives of the Non-Chosen

This short narrative about Esau's wives matches the concluding panel of this section of the Yaaqov story in Genesis 27:41-28:9, which also focuses on Yaaqov and Esau's wives.

Esau is set on analogy with the non-chosen lineage of Cain that culminated in the seventh generation from Adam and Eve, Lemek.

Lemek is the first figure in the story of the Bible to take two wives ([Gen. 4:19](#)), which deviates from the ideal portrait of Adam and Eve in Eden ([Gen. 2:24](#)).

Just as Lemek is a heightened image of Cain's violence, Esau will continue that heritage of volatility and violence toward his brother.

Esau takes "Hittite" wives, that is, wives from outside his extended family. The last Hittites we met were those living in Hebron, with whom Abraham negotiated to buy the plot of land and the burial cave of Makpelah (see [Gen. 23](#)). The Hittites, as such, have not been portrayed in negative terms. But Abraham did show great concern that Yitskhaq not marry a "daughter of the Canaanites" ([Gen. 24:3](#)), and that he should only marry some from Shem's chosen lineage ([Gen. 24:7-8](#)). The fact that Esau would marry outside the extended family is grievous to Yitskhaq and Rivqah, and only furthers the narrative portrait that Esau is not the son who will inherit the blessing of Eden given to their family.

Esau is depicted as merging into the culture of Canaan. But it is surely ironic that Esau married a Canaanite woman named Yehudith ("Woman of Judah")!

Yitskhaq's Plan and Rivqah's Counterplan

A- Yitskhaq's Plan to Esau

¹ And it came about when **Yitskhaq was old** ,
and his eyes became weak,
and he called Esau his son, his big one,

and he said to him, "My son!"
And he said to him, "Look, it's me."

² And he said, "Look, **I am old** .
I do not know the day of **my death** .

³ And now, please lift up your tools and your quiver and your bow,
and go out to the field,
and hunt for me hunted-game,

⁴ and **make for me tasty-things just as I love,**

and **bring it to me so I may eat** ,
on account of which my being can bless you before I die ."

⁵ Now, Rivqah was listening
as Yitskhaq spoke to Esau his son,
and Esau went to the field to hunt hunted-game to bring.

A' - Rivqah's Counterplan to Yaaqov

⁶ **But Rivqah said to Yaaqov her son** , saying,
"Look, I have listened to your father speaking to Esau your brother, saying,
⁷ **'Bring to me hunted-game,**
and make for me tasty-things,
so I can eat and **so I can bless you** before Yahweh **before my death .'**
⁸ So now, my son, **listen to my voice** , to what I am commanding you:
⁹ Please **go** to the flock,
and **take** for me from there two kids of goats, good ones,
and **I will make them as tasty-things for your father, just as he loves,**
¹⁰ and you will bring them to your father,
and he will eat , **on account of which he will bless you before his death ."**

¹¹ **And Yaaqov said to Rivqah his mother** ,
"Look, Esau my brother is a man of hair,
and I am a man of smoothness.
¹² Perhaps my father will feel me,
and I will be like a deceiver in his eyes,
and I will bring upon myself a **curse** and not a **blessing** ."

¹³ **And his mother said to him** ,
"May your **curse** be upon me, my son.
However, **listen to my voice** ,
and **go, take** for me!"

A'' - Rivqah's Counterplan Begins

¹⁴ And he **went**
and he **took** ,
and he brought to his mother,
and his mother **made tasty-things just as his father loved.**

¹⁵ And Rivqah **took** the clothes of her son, the bigger one,
the desirable ones that were with her in the house,
and she clothed Yaaqov her son, the smaller one,

¹⁶ and the skins of the kids of goats
she clothed upon his hands,
and upon the smoothness of his neck.

¹⁷ And she **gave** **the tasty things** and the bread which she made
into the hand of Yaaqov her son.

¹⁸ And he **went** to his father,

Genesis 27:1-18. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Like Hungry Father, Like Hungry Son

In Genesis 25:19-34, we saw Yitskhaq and Rivqah contrasted with Abraham and Sarah. When faced with the challenge of infertility, Yitskhaq turned to Yahweh in prayer and discovered God's creative power to bring about life out of non-life.

In that story, Rivqah and Yitskhaq were offered an oracle about their two sons: the older would be a servant to the younger. The Eden blessing that Yitskhaq receives in Genesis 26:1-5 is to be passed onto the younger son, not the older. But we know from Genesis 25:27 that "Yitskhaq loved Esau, because hunted game was in his mouth."

Just as Esau's appetite overpowered him and drove him to foolishly trade his *bekorah* ("firstborn right") for a bowl of food, so now Yitskhaq will give away God's *berakah* to the son God didn't choose.

Like Deceptive Mother, Like Deceptive Son

Similar to the father/son analogy between Esau and Yitskhaq, the narrative highlights a mother/son analogy between Yaaqov and Rivqah.

Just as Yaaqov swindled Esau out of the firstborn right for a bowl of food, now Rivqah will trick Yitskhaq into given the Eden blessing to her favored son.

Everyone's motives in this story are twisted and self-oriented. No one seems aware that the story of God's pursuit of humanity is at stake here!

The Language of Genesis 2-3

This story is riddled with the vocabulary of the Eden-failure story from Genesis 2-3. The two stories have been brought into a meaningful relationship that illuminates the narrative gaps in both scenes.

The key vocabulary items repeated in both stories are:

- Knowledge and death
- Man and woman (who are husband and wife)
- Eyes, see, take, desire, give, eat
- Blessing, curse
- Listen to the voice

Adam and Eve/Yitskhaq and Esau are willing to contradict the word of God (about the tree/about the sons) in pursuit of their own purposes (desire to eat).

The women's plans (Eve and Rivqah) are to achieve a good goal but in the wrong timing and in the wrong way.

- Eve's desire for knowledge is not in and of itself wrong.
- Rivqah's desire to make sure the younger son is blessed is not in and of itself wrong.
- What is wrong is that the women achieve their goals by violating the divine word.

In Eve's story, she is deceived and led along by her desire. In Rivqah's story, she is led by her desire, and so she becomes a deceiver.

The deceiver's desire is to usurp the place of the firstborn in the family.

- In Genesis 3, the deceiving snake (who was made subject to the humans in Gen. 1:26-28) deceives the latecomer in order to usurp their authority over the animals.
- In Genesis 27, the deceiving mother and son (who was elevated in Gen. 25) deceives the firstborn to usurp his authority.

The deceiver brings a curse upon themselves for their treachery (Gen. 3:14, 27:12-13).

Yaaqov is disguised with the form of an animal skin to deceive his father. Is the snake form also a "disguise" of a spiritual being?

The snake says that only after eating the fruit will the humans' eyes be opened (the implication being that their eyes are closed in some way). Rivqah and Yaaqov can only deceive Yitskhaq because his eyes are "closed" from old age.

Genesis 26:34-28:9	Genesis 1-3
Gen. 27:1 "And [Yitskhaq's] eyes were weak/dim to be seeing"	Gen. 3 The humans' eyes are "opened" because of the forbidden food.
Gen. 27:4, 7 Yitskhaq requests that Esau bring fresh game "that I may eat (אכל), on account of which (בעבור) my being will bless you (ברוך) before I die (מוות)."	Gen. 3:6 "and she took and she ate (אכל)" Gen. 3:17 " cursed (ארורה) is the ground on account of you (בעבורך)"
Gen. 27:8 "And now my son, listen to my voice (בקול שמע) to what I am commanding (צוה) you."	Gen. 3:17 "And to the man he said, 'Because you have listened to the voice (בקול + שמע) of your wife and ate of the tree that I commanded (צוה) you ...'"
<i>Detailed Comparison of Genesis 27-28 and Genesis 2-3. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).</i>	

Genesis 26:34-28:9

Gen. 27:9 "Go now to the flock **and take** (לק"ח) for me two young goats, **good ones** (טוב) ... **that he may eat** (אכל) and **bless** (ברך) you before **his death** (מות)"

Gen. 27:12-13 "'Perhaps I will be **in his eyes** (עיניו) like one who makes a mockery, and I will bring upon myself **a curse and not a blessing** ' (ברכה ולא קללה). And she said, 'May your **curse** (קללה) be upon me my son. Just **listen to my voice** (בקול שמ"ע) and go and **take** (לק"ח) for me.'"

Gen. 27:14-15 "And he went **and he took** (ויקח) and he brought to his mother ... And **she took** (ותקח) the clothes of Esau her son, the bigger one, **the desirable ones** (החמדת) which were with her ..."

Gen. 27:15 "And she **clothed** (ותלבש) Yaaqov her son, the little one, and with **the skins** (ערת) of the goats **she clothed** (והלבישה) over **his hands** "

Gen. 27:17 "And she gave (ותתן) the tasty foods and the bread which she made into the hand of Yaaqov her son."

Gen. 27:33 "Who then is the one who hunted game and brought to me **and I ate from all** (מכל ואכל) ..."

Gen. 27:35-36 "'Your brother came in **deceit** (במרמה), **and he took** (ויקח) your blessing.' And [Esau] said, 'Isn't he rightly called **heel/deceiver** (יעקב), for he **heeled/deceived** (עק"ב) **me two times? He took** (לק"ח) **my birthright** (בכרה), and **he took** (לק"ח) **my blessing** (ברכה).'"

Genesis 1-3

Gen. 3:6 "And she took (לקח) from its fruit and she ate (אכל)"

Gen. 3:17 "And to the man he said, 'Because **you have listened to the voice** (בקול + שמע) of your wife and ate of the tree that I **commanded** (צוה) you ... **cursed** (ארורה) is the ground on account of you.'"

Gen. 3:6 "And the woman saw that the tree was good for eating, and desirable (תאוה) to the eyes, and desirable (נחמד) for becoming wise, and she took (לקח) ..."

Gen. 3:21 "And God made for the man and his wife garments of **skin** (עור) and he **clothed them** (וילבשם)"

Gen. 3:6 "and she took from its fruit and she ate and she gave (ותתן) to her husband and he ate."

Gen. 2:16 "from every/all (מכל) trees in the garden you may eat (תאכל);" cf. also Gen. 3:1-2

Gen. 3:13 "And she said, 'The snake deceived me (נשא) and I ate'"

Detailed Comparison of Genesis 27-28 and Genesis 2-3. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Genesis 26:34-28:9	Genesis 1-3
Gen. 27:43 "And now my son, listen to my voice (בקול שמ"ע)"	Gen. 3:17 "because you have listened to the voice (שמע + בקול) of your wife"
Gen. 27:45 "Dwell [in Aram] for a few days, until ... he forgets that which you have done to him (לו עשית אשר את)"	Gen. 3:13 "and God said to the woman, 'What is this you have done? (מה זאת עשית)'" Gen. 3:14 "And God said to the snake, 'Because you have done this thing (זאת עשית כי) ...'"
Gen. 28:3 "May El Shaddai bleess you and make you fruitful and multiply ."	Gen. 1:28 "And God blessed them and said be fruitful and multiply "
<i>Detailed Comparison of Genesis 27-28 and Genesis 2-3. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).</i>	

Reflection Question

How is Genesis 27:1-18 a meditation on children replaying and intensifying the failures of their ancestors?